Unit 10 — A Classic Text (Leistungsfach focus)

Track E · Klasse 11 · Niveau E (Basisfach / Leistungsfach)

Learning objectives I

- *I can read three soliloquies from Shakespeare's Macbeth* (LF set text) and write a 450-word literary essay with a complex thesis.
- *I can engage Early Modern English vocabulary and rhythm with confidence.*
- *I can hold the Leistungsfach (advanced course) register: complex argument, integrated close reading, sustained voice.*

Lead-in I

The Leistungsfach (advanced course) Englisch class is reading Shakespeare's *Macbeth* (1606) over six weeks. Today's checkpoint covers three soliloquies: 1.7 (*If it were done*), 2.1 (*Is this a dagger*), and 5.5 (*Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow*). The class has been keeping a soliloquy log: one image, one rhythm-break, one moral move per soliloquy.

Reading I

Reading — three Macbeth soliloquies (extracts)
1.7 (Macbeth): If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well / It were done quickly: …
2.1 (Macbeth): Is this a dagger which I see before me, / The handle toward my hand?
5.5 (Macbeth): Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow, / Creeps in this petty pace from day to day, …

Leistungsfach (advanced course) register
Marks of LF register:

- Sustained close reading of language and rhythm.

Reading II

- Integrated quotation rather than block-quotes.
- Tracking of one argument over 4-6 paragraphs.
- Confident use of literary vocabulary (*soliloquy, blank verse, iambic pentameter, caesura, syntactic inversion, dramatic irony*).
- Engagement with at least one piece of critical commentary or contextual frame.

Practise I

Niveau E — controlled

1. Match: soliloquy → speech alone on stage; blank verse → unrhymed iambic pentameter; caesura → mid-line pause.
2. T or F: 1.7 explores moral hesitation; 2.1 stages hallucinated commitment; 5.5 collapses future-tense confidence.

Niveau E — productive

3. Build 3 close-reading sentences using Leistungsfach register on the three soliloquies.

Your turn I

Literary essay, 450 words (Leistungsfach register). Argue a single complex thesis tracing how Macbeth's relationship to time changes across the three soliloquies. Use 4 integrated quotes + 6 academic discourse markers + 1 cleft.

Sample

Macbeth's three central soliloquies — 1.7, 2.1, and 5.5 — track a deterioration in his relationship to time, and that deterioration is, I shall argue, the most precise way to read his moral collapse. In 1.7, Macbeth approaches the prospective murder as a problem of completion: "If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well / It were done quickly". The structure of the argument is conditional, and the tense is hypothetical; Macbeth is still inside a world in which an act could be

Your turn II

sealed off from its consequences. The repetition of *done* signals, however, an over-confidence the verse itself destabilises by the end of the speech. By contrast, in 2.1 Macbeth has stepped into the present imperative: *"Is this a dagger which I see before me, / The handle toward my hand?"*. The hallucinated dagger is, accordingly, a present-tense object that compels rather than waits. It is precisely the shift from the conditional of 1.7 to the perceptual present of 2.1 that marks Macbeth's loss of deliberative space. Whatever moral hesitation remained in 1.7 is, here, hijacked by an image he neither chose nor can refuse. In 5.5, the deterioration completes itself in the famous *"tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow"* — three futures emptied of force by their own repetition. What had been hypothetical in 1.7 and present-compelling in 2.1 becomes, in 5.5, a *"petty pace from day to day"*: a future that will only ever shuffle into more of itself. More

Your turn III

specifically, the verse-rhythm collapses with the meaning: the iambic pentameter loses its drive; the line *”creeps in this petty pace”* enacts the very tedium it describes. Critics have read 5.5 as nihilist; in my reading, it is the structural completion of the arc begun in 1.7. Macbeth’s collapse is the collapse of his ability to imagine time as anything other than a ledger of repetition. In this regard, the play stages moral failure not as a single act but as the drying up of the tense-system itself — and the soliloquies do most of that work without the help of any other character.

Reflect I

- I can read three soliloquies and trace a complex thesis across them.
- I can hold the Leistungsfach register over 450 words.
- I can integrate four quotes without breaking voice.

Further reading / listening I

- Stephen Greenblatt, *Will in the World* — accessible Shakespeare biography.
- Frank Kermode, *Shakespeare's Language*.